

The Knights Templar

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The Templars arrived in England in 1128, and established their headquarters in Chancery Lane near to Holborn. They moved in 1184 to a site now known as the Temple, with its northern boundary on Fleet Street.

The Knights Templar were a military order of monks founded by a French knight in 1109 to protect pilgrims travelling to Jerusalem, captured for Christendom during the First Crusade. In 1120, they made their headquarters on the Temple Mount in Jerusalem. From this, they took their name of the “Poor Knights of Christ and the Temple of Solomon”, often shortened to the Templars.

The Order obtained the backing of Bernard of Clairvaux, founder of the Cistercian Order. In 1129, the Templars were officially approved by the French Church. In 1135, Pope Innocent II gave a donation to the Order, and in 1139 granted them exemption from local laws, allowing them to cross borders freely, avoid taxes, and answer only to the Pope.

Individuals joining the Order took vows of poverty, chastity and obedience. Militarily, this made them a disciplined and effective fighting force with a clear chain of command. Only about 10% of the Templars were knights; the remainder served in a wide variety of supporting roles.

The Order became very rich through donations, gifts and legacies, developing a management structure for its land and wealth. Over time, it became the first international conglomerate, with interests in banking, shipping and commerce.



Tombs in Temple Church, London. William Marshal, 1st Earl of Pembroke, is in the far right glass case, with his son, the 2nd earl, on the far left



the badge of the Knights Templar, showing two Knights on one horse to emphasise their poverty

As they grew more powerful, they also created powerful enemies, especially kings who had borrowed heavily from them. The fall of Jerusalem in 1244, followed by the fall of Acre in 1291, removed the Templars’ main purpose and gave Philip IV of France the opportunity to act. In 1309, the Grand Master, Jacques de Molay, and many French Templars were arrested. Many were tortured into confessing heresy and some were burnt at the stake. The Pope, then based in Avignon and under the control of the French

king, dissolved the Order and transferred its property to the Knights Hospitallers.

The history of the Knights Templar in England began in 1128, when the Grand Master visited to raise men and money for the Crusades. King Henry II granted the Templars land near the River Fleet, now the Inner and Middle Temple, including the Temple Church, built in the distinctive Templar style. The church contains effigies of nine knights, including William Marshal (1146–1219), Earl of Pembroke. The Templars also owned land north of Fleet Street, including Ficket’s Croft, used for jousts, training and exercising horses.

The Templars rapidly established large landholdings across England. The name “Temple” occurs in many place names, such as Temple Meads in Bristol, usually indicating former Templar ownership.

The Wikipedia article on the Knights Templar in England lists 16 Templar churches and 10 place names associated with the Order. It also notes that Baldock was founded by the Templars, Royston Cave contains Templar relics, South Witham has the only fully preserved Templar preceptory in Western Europe, and Denny Abbey was also one of their preceptories.